

But some midlife crises manifest themselves in other ways. It's not always the hot young thing that causes a breach in the family dynasty; it could be addiction or other reckless behaviors. Your partner still feels that something is missing, so he or she tries to fill the void in other ways. Alcohol, drugs, gambling and excessive debt all pose a serious threat to your investments. And I'm not just talking about your stock portfolio: I mean the investments you've made in your partnership and in your family dynasty. While divorce is costly, there are times when it may actually be *less* costly than remaining together.

I recommend a three-strikes-you're-out policy. If your partner struggles with any of the following, give him or her three chances to get help. But if your partner slips back into old habits after the third time, it's a deal breaker. Get out while you can.

Alcohol/Drugs

According to a study by the Canadian Centre on Substance Abuse, alcohol abuse costs the nation a whopping \$14.6 billion each year. That includes \$7.1 billion in lost productivity due to illness and premature death, \$3.3 billion for direct health-care costs, and \$3.1 billion for enforcement costs. Break that number down and every Canadian citizen is paying \$465 a year to fund the country's alcoholics.

My birth father, Terry, was a borderline alcoholic, so I've seen firsthand how alcoholism can wreak devastation on a family. If after three stints in AA, therapy or rehab, your partner is still unable to stay away from the bottle, your marriage is in trouble and you should walk away.